

Notes and Queries

[The editors will welcome as contributions to this section of the *California Folklore Quarterly* either small items of traditional materials or inquiries designed to elicit information about such materials. In general, discussion of the materials here offered will be brief. Records of facts likely to be lost or overlooked, and inquiries which our readers may be able to answer—such items will be the typical ones.]

The Lost Woman of San Nicolás.—Since my query on *The Wild Girl of the Santa Barbara Channel Islands*¹ I have had the opportunity to gather the following three more narratives on the same topic which throw additional light on the nature of this popular story and the facts which have given rise to it. They follow exactly as I received them from Lieutenant L. L. Hanchett of Santa Ana Army Air Base and Mr. Lennox Tierney of Altadena, California. It is to be hoped that some California folklorist who has access to a good research library will sometime patch all this scattered information into a comprehensive account of the historical facts and the resultant folk narratives. The little information that I have collected, quite accidentally, makes me believe that the “Lost Woman of San Nicolás” has won a permanent place in the oral tradition of the California coast.

1.

In the 'seventies or 'eighties of the last century a fishing or hunting party had landed on San Nicolás Island, the most remote of the Santa Barbara Channel Island group. They discovered on the island a mature woman—a pure-blooded Indian. She had long since lost the power of speech and had reverted to a semiwild condition. She was taken to the mainland, where she eventually learned enough English to tell her story. She was the only survivor of a massacre which had victimized all the other Indians then living on the island. This massacre had occurred sometime in the early years of the nineteenth century when she was still a child. The narrator said that it was believed the massacre of the Indian inhabitants of San Nicolás Island had been effected by Russian sea-otter hunters. The narrator further affirms that this story of the lone survivor of the massacre is a historical fact and that he believes it is told by Bancroft.

LIEUTENANT L. L. HANCHETT

Santa Ana Army Air Base

November 25, 1943

2.

A number of years ago the Bureau of Indian Affairs removed all the Indians from San Nicolás Island. One young girl broke away from the group and they were unable to recapture her. Hence she was left on the island and her presence there was known to inhabitants of the near-by islands and mainland.

¹ *California Folklore Quarterly*, II, 149–150.

Not long ago a party of fishermen put in to San Nicolás and captured the then mature Indian woman. She was taken to Santa Barbara, where she lived for a few years after her capture. She had at the time of capture entirely lost the power of speech and was living in a semiwild state.

LIEUTENANT L. L. HANCHETT

Santa Ana Army Air Base

November 26, 1943

3.

It is a pleasure to pass on to you such information as I have on the "Lost Woman of San Nicolás". . .

The "Lost Woman" was baptized at Santa Barbara Mission after her rescue and christened "Juana María Better-Than-Nothing"—the latter part of the name being taken from the name of the rescuing ship. She was left on the island when a ship was sent to remove the last remnant of the native population in 1830. She was found in 1851 and had not entirely lost the power of speech, but since all her race had in the meantime perished, no one could understand her. The sole word from her vocabulary that has survived is "manequana" and it was never translated. The Indians of San Nicolás had been decimated by Russian trappers but not wiped out and the purpose of the 1830 expedition was to remove them for safety's sake to one of the mainland missions. There is no record of María ever learning any English, but before they took her off the island she had indicated by sign language something of what her life had been like—how she had caught birds, fish, and sea lions, built her huts of whale ribs and bird skins, and of what her diet had consisted.

There is, if I remember correctly, an account in John Steven McGroarty's book *California*; also, Chapter XXVIII of *The Channel Islands of California*, by Charles Frederick Holder, tells the story of her life and the Brown-Nidever party who found her. Holder relates how her garments were sent to the Vatican Museum in Rome for permanent display. She lived just six months in Santa Barbara.

(From a letter to Lt. A. E. Fife written by Lennox Tierney of Altadena, California, December, 1943.)

Santa Ana Army Air Base

LIEUTENANT AUSTIN E. FIFE

January 4, 1944

The Use of Hard Money in the West.—Why is it that the use of gold and silver, hard money, has been a tradition in the West, particularly in San Francisco, from the earliest days? I have heard two reasons given. One is that San Franciscans were suspicious of paper money, especially after the suspension of specie payment on December 31, 1861. Second is that all transactions during the mining days were in gold or silver and that the use of metal currency had become a strong habit.

A glance at the economic history of the country may help to fix the background for a discussion of this question. Shortly after the Civil War began it was found impossible to maintain the gold standard, and from 1861 until January 1, 1879, when specie payment was resumed ("the way to resume is to resume"), the country was on a paper basis. During the ups and downs of panic and prosperity till October, 1917, paper money was freely redeemed in